low in the Deccan, in the shadow of Ahmadnagar. ‘When his son died,’ wrote Abu’l Fazl about Murad, ‘the jewel of wisdom grew dim, and he set himself down to drink in company with foolish sensualists.’ Abdur Rahim had already complained to the Padshah of Murad’s excessive drinking but now Murad drank even more in a suicidal bid to escape his pain. ‘Excessive drinking brought on epilepsy, and he did not apply his mind to getting better. He concealed his pains and did not digest his food,’ wrote Abu’l Fazl about the prince who was getting progressively more debilitated. Learning that Abu’l Fazl was on his way to meet him, Murad left Shahpur ‘out of shame for his drunkenness’ and marched towards Ahmadnagar, in a last, desperate bid to take the city. In Jalnapur, near Daulatabad, Murad suffered from a final fit and died of delirium tremens at the age of twenty-nine.

When Abu’l Fazl arrived at Murad’s war camp near Daulatabad, he found it in a near mutinous condition. ‘There I saw what may no other person see!’ exclaimed Abu’l Fazl, for Murad’s men were deserting in droves, from confusion and lack of pay, in a country deemed utterly foreign and unfathomable. Abu’l Fazl, with considerable aplomb and skill began to try to turn the situation around. He sent Murad’s body to Shahpur with trusted servants and gathered together all the money he could to pay the soldiers and stem the exodus of men. ‘The management of the troops was carried on in an excellent way,’ he wrote with evident satisfaction, ‘and beyond the expectations of contemporaries.’ Abu’l Fazl used the 3,000 horsemen under his command to restore confidence and order among the soldiers, and thus bolstered, the retinue headed towards Ahmadnagar. Abu’l Fazl even had the time to ruminate on the irony of his condition when ‘the tongue of suspicion…had sent me far away from court but (God) had made this a source of high promotion and marked them with enduring shame’.

Meanwhile, the Mughal harem had finally arrived from Lahore to the court at Agra. Akbar was delighted and called for Khurram and Hamida Banu but his mother had terrible news for the Padshah. Abu’l Fazl’s report from the Deccan had not been conveyed to Akbar, and it fell to Hamida Banu to inform the Padshah of the death of his son. Akbar mourned the death of his child, who had once shown such promise, in the discreet company of the grieving women.

After the death of Murad, Akbar wanted to dispatch Salim to the Deccan but the prince, once again, dithered. In frustration, Akbar decided to send Daniyal instead. He accompanied the prince on the first leg of the